4.1 The Spanish and Mexicans in California

Maps tell us about geography, but they also tell us about history. Just look at a map of California, and you'll see names such as Los Angeles, Palo Alto, and Sierra Nevada—evidence of a past rooted in Spanish culture.

MAIN IDEA Long before the United States acquired California, Spanish and Mexican settlers were founding missions and settlements there.



This statue of Junípero Serra, sculpted by Arthur Putnam in 1918, is located in the cemetery garden at Mission San Francisco. Serra founded Mission San Francisco, also known as Mission Dolores, in 1776.

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SPANISH MISSIONS IN CALIFORNIA

As you have read, Spanish conquistadors first explored and claimed the area that is now California in the 16th century. The Spanish were slow to settle in California. The colonial government considered California too far north from its base in Mexico for the region to be a priority. In the 1700s, however, British and Russian fur traders expanded westward into the region to take advantage of the land's natural resources. As a defensive measure, Spain sent an expedition to establish communities in southern California in 1769.

One member of the expedition was **Father Junípero Serra** (hoo-NEE-peh-roh SEH-rah), a Catholic priest from Spain. Serra founded the first mission in California at San Diego. His relationship to the Native Americans he sought to convert to Christianity is still the subject of controversy. Some historians see him as a courageous and generous man who worked hard to improve Native American lives. Others point to his participation in the mistreatment and enslavement of Native Americans.

Over time, the Spanish established 21 missions in California. The names of these missions echo the cities that eventually grew up around them, such as San Francisco, Santa Clara, and San Luis Obispo.

The mission system itself was complicated. Mission residents established farms on the nearby lands and tried to convert Native Americans to Christianity. Spanish treatment of Native Americans was often cruel. Many settlers exploited and enslaved Native Americans they encountered near their farms. They pushed thousands of Native Americans off their land and forced hundreds of others to live and work at the missions.

MEXICAN RULE OF CALIFORNIA

When Mexico gained independence from Spain in 1821, California was one of the new nation's northernmost territories. Because of its enormous size and its great distance from Mexico City, California was difficult for Mexico to rule. As in Texas, the local Mexican government was often ineffective and corrupt.

In 1824, Mexico passed an act that granted land to settlers in the form of large estates. These land grants became new estates, called **ranchos**, which consisted of sprawling tracts of land covering thousands of acres. The ranchos formed the basis of the economy of the Mexican settlements in the region. The rancheros, or owners, raised huge herds of cattle and traded hides and the processed fat of the cattle for manufactured goods along the Pacific coast.

The economy expanded as American traders, trappers, farmers, and businesspeople moved into the territory in the decades after Mexican independence. Some received land grants for ranchos or other parcels of land.

One of these new settlers was a Swiss immigrant named **John Sutter**, who received several land grants from the Mexican government to start a colony. In 1843, he built what became known as Sutter's Fort, a huge, high-walled adobe structure at the future site of Sacramento. Sutter kept herds of cattle like other California rancheros, but he also helped diversify the region's economy and agriculture by raising grapes and wheat.

By 1848, Americans who had moved to California accounted for more than half of its non-Native American population. They faced a government they felt did not represent them, and as a result, the Americans entertained the idea of independence from Mexico.

They got their wish with the signing of the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo in 1848. The United States acquired California just in time for an amazing discovery at a sawmill that John Sutter was building in the foothills of the Sierra Nevada.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why did the Spanish establish communities in California?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** How were the histories of Texas and California alike under the rule of Spain and Mexico?
3. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** How did the California economy change as American settlers received land grants?

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